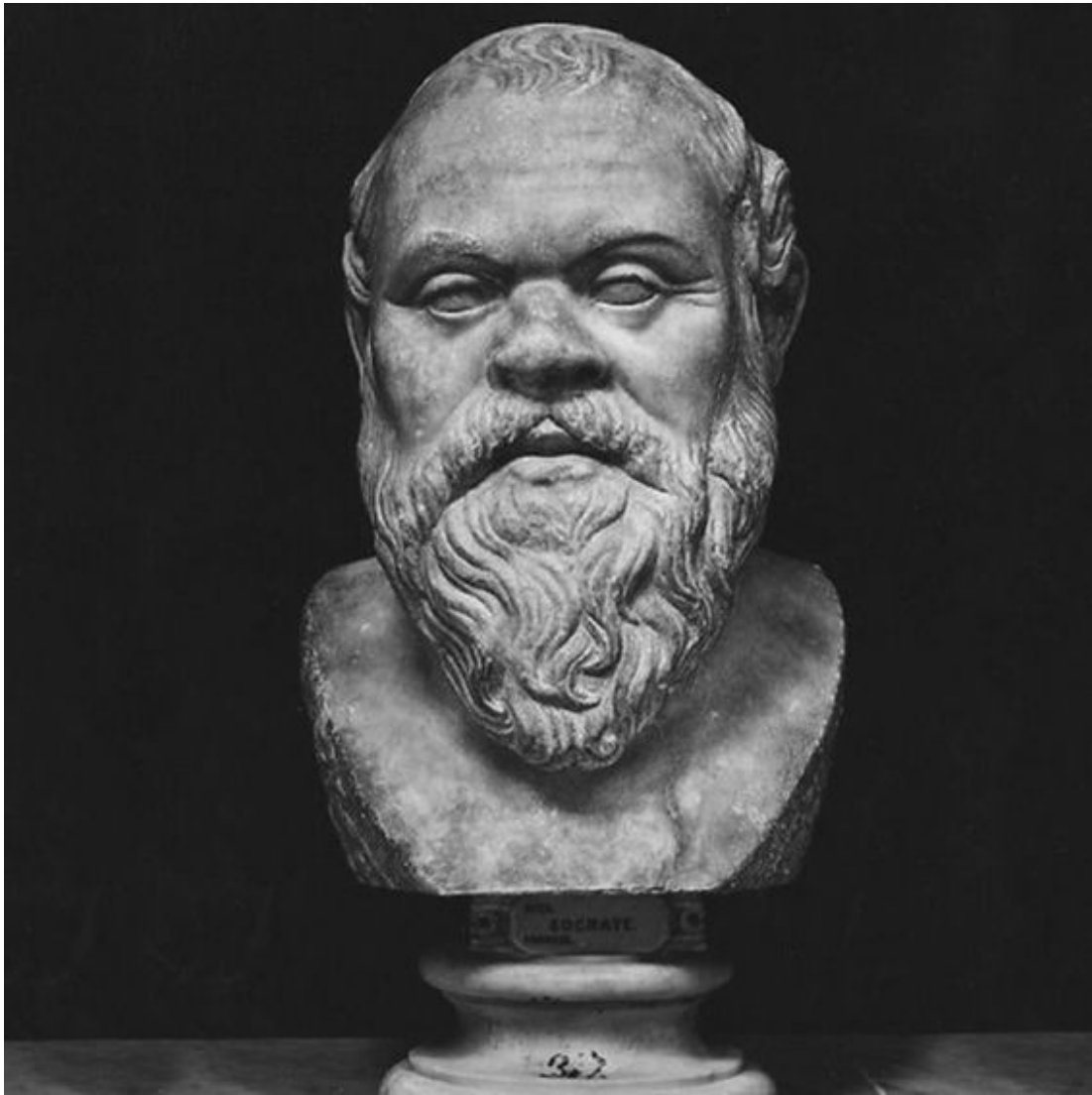


Socrates and the dialectical method



The great philosopher Socrates was one of the foremost critics of sophism: he not only condemned their charging for wisdom, but also felt that philosophical enquiry should aim to elicit truth, not simply win a debate. However, this did not stop him adopting some of the sophists' techniques of argument; having studied earlier philosophers, he realized that their method of reasoning was weak and based on speculation.

Socrates set out to rigorously examine fundamental questions through reasoned argument in dialogue with others of opposing views – a technique

now known as the dialectical method. His approach was to start from the idea that 'I only know that I know nothing', and through discussion with a person or group try to arrive at agreed definitions. Starting with a seemingly simple question such as 'What is justice?', he would interrogate his subject relentlessly with further questions that exposed inconsistencies and contradictions, challenging assumptions and conventional beliefs in order to provide insights.